

VRA Core 4 XML Editor — User Manual

This guide covers day-to-day use of the editor: opening and creating records, filling them in, syncing them with linked image files, and moving records through review, offline or on. It describes the app as it actually behaves — if something here doesn't match what you see on screen, that's worth reporting.

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Getting started

When the app opens with no record loaded, the toolbar offers four starting points:

- **Create** — start a brand-new, blank record. You'll be asked for a record type (work, image, or collection) and a record ID. The record isn't written to disk until you Save or Submit it.
- **Open** — pick an existing record from the *edit* folder to work on.
- **Review** — pick a record waiting in the *pending* folder (one that's already been submitted) to approve or reject.
- **Import** — merge newly-arrived source files from the *ingest* folder into *edit*, so they show up in Open's list.

This home screen also shows a diagram of the whole record lifecycle — Ingest, Edit, Pending, Reviewed, Released — labelled with the exact button that moves a record from one to the next, and a reminder that Settings is where those folders themselves get configured. Worth a glance if you're new to the workflow.

Home returns you to this starting screen from anywhere.

The toolbar

The buttons across the top are grouped into four clusters, separated by thin vertical dividers:

1. **Navigation** — Home, Open, Create, Review, Import. Always available.

2. **Record actions** — Save, Undo, Submit/Approve, Reject, Cancel. Only shown once a record is open; act on that record specifically.
3. **View toggles** — Show XML, Review Notes, Advanced View, Sync Media. Switch how the current record is displayed, or open a tool for it; none of them change its content on their own.
4. **Admin** — Settings, Audits, Help, About. Rarely-needed, styled smaller and muted so they don't compete for attention.

A colored strip just below the toolbar (**Editing — filename** or **Reviewing — filename**) shows which record you have open and whether you're editing it or reviewing it — the two have real differences in what the action buttons do, so it's worth a glance before clicking Submit or Approve.

If you try to navigate away (Home, Open, Create, or Review) while a record has unsaved changes, you'll be asked whether to save, discard, or stay put — nothing is silently lost.

Editing a record (Simple view)

This is the default view, and the one most cataloguing work happens in. It has two panes:

- **Left — Sections.** One row per part of the record (Titles, People, Dates, Measurements, and so on). Bold rows already have content, with a count in parentheses; grey italic rows (+ **Add ...**) are sections this record doesn't have yet — click one to add it.
- **Right — the form** for whichever section is selected. Each existing entry is shown as its own card, with + **Add** buttons at the bottom for adding another. Every card and every section can be removed individually (**Remove this ...**); removing is always undoable.

Fields with a fixed vocabulary (relation type, material type, and about a dozen others defined by the VRA Core 4 schema) show as a dropdown instead of free text — the options offered are exactly the ones the schema allows, so there's no risk of typing an invalid value. Some sections (People, Dates, Locations, Materials, Rights, ...) also have their own **Type:** dropdown at the top of the card, for the same reason.

Display translations — most sections can carry a short, language-tagged summary alongside (or instead of) the itemized detail underneath. Use + **Add translations (Display)** to add one.

Controlled vocabularies and authority search

Fields that reference a named authority (an artist's name, a place, a subject term, a material) have a **Search authority...** button next to them. It searches the relevant vocabulary — VIAF, Getty AAT/ TGN/ ULAN, GNS, or the Library of Congress vocabularies (LCSH, LCNAF, LCGFT, LCTGM), depending on the field — and, once you pick a result, fills in the linked-authority details (record ID and link) for you automatically. Results are cached locally, so a repeated or related search doesn't need the network again.

Syncing with a linked image file

Only relevant to **image** records, and only shown once one is open. Click **Sync Media** to open it. There's no persisted link remembered between sessions — the app makes a best guess from the filename each time, or you're asked to browse to the right file yourself.

It compares seven of the record's own fields — Title, Description, Rights, People, Subjects, creation Date, and Location — against whatever the image file's own EXIF/IPTC metadata already says, and shows each as one of:

- **In sync** — the record and the file already agree; nothing to do.
- **Fill record** — the file has it, the record doesn't; can be copied in.
- **Fill file** — the record has it, the file doesn't; can be copied out to the file's metadata.
- **Conflict** — the two disagree; pick which one wins.

Pixel dimensions, resolution, and file size are always shown too, read fresh from the file, purely for information — there's nothing to choose there. Tick or choose which direction each row should go, then **Sync** applies your choices — this is the only step here that writes to the image file itself.

There's also an optional checkbox to copy the image to sit alongside the record's own XML file (renamed to match the record's ID) as part of the same sync — useful the first time you link a file that's sitting somewhere else, so the two stay together going forward.

Review Notes

A place for a reviewer to leave notes for the editor (or vice versa) without it being part of the actual cataloguing data — notes are stored separately from the record's own fields. Toggle the panel with **Review Notes**; it opens automatically when you load a record that has unresolved notes on it, so they're hard to miss. Each note can be marked resolved or removed.

Undo

Undo (or Ctrl+Z) reverts the last change — a field edit, an add, a remove, anything done inside the sectioned form or the tree editor. It's a full document snapshot each time, not a per-character history, so a burst of typing into the same field collapses into a single undo step; adding or removing something always gets its own step. It does **not** cover Sync Media's file-writing step (see Tips below).

Saving, submitting, and reviewing

- **Save** writes the record to the *edit* folder as-is. The record doesn't need to be complete or fully valid to save your progress.
- **Submit** moves the record from *edit* into *pending*, for review. Unlike Save, this **does** require the record to be schema-valid — if it isn't, you'll see an explanation of what's wrong rather than the submission going through.
- **Approve** (while reviewing a pending record) moves it into *reviewed* — the final archive location.
- **Reject** (while reviewing) sends it into *rejected*, for the original editor to revisit. Approve and Reject don't re-validate — a reviewer needs to be able to reject something broken without having to fix it themselves first.
- **Cancel** discards any unsaved changes (after confirming, if there are any) and returns to the start screen — the same as Home.

After Save, Submit, Approve, or Reject, you'll be asked for a short commit comment; if you give one, the change is recorded in the archive's shared version history under your name — see **Audits**

below for browsing and restoring from that history. Leaving the comment blank just skips that step; the save/submit itself has already happened either way.

The Advanced view

Toggle **Advanced View** to switch from the sectioned form to a raw structure tree (left) and a single-element editor (right). This exposes every field the schema allows, including ones the Simple view's section list doesn't surface directly, and is useful for unusual or highly detailed records. **Show XML** works in either view, and highlights whichever element is currently selected.

Audits: browsing and restoring history

Click **Audits** (always available, in the Admin cluster) to see every past revision recorded via the commit-comment prompt above — one row per file changed in a commit, most recent first, with who made it and when. Type in the filter box to narrow it down by filename.

Select a revision and click **Restore to New File...** (or just double-click the row) to write that exact past version into a new file in the *edit* folder, under whatever name you choose — this never overwrites anything, and the new file is opened for you afterward, going through the same unsaved-work check as Open or Create.

Working offline

For working somewhere with no network at all — a field trip, a site visit, anywhere without a signal. This only ever involves the *edit* folder: the records actively being worked on, typically a modest, everyday-sized amount — not the reviewed/approved archive behind it, which is never touched and can be far larger.

Before you go — open **Settings**, and under **Offline Work** click **Start Offline Staging...** Choose a local folder; the app copies the current *edit* folder into it and points Edit there. Click **Save** to actually switch over.

While you're away — use the app exactly as normal: Open, Create, Save all work against your local copy. Hold off on **Submit** until you're back online — *pending* still points at the real, currently unreachable archive, so a Submit attempt while offline will simply tell you it can't reach that folder rather than going through.

When you're back — open **Settings** again and click **Reconcile Offline Changes....** This lists every record that actually needs attention — new ones you created, ones you edited — and applies the straightforward ones for you in one go. If a record was *also* changed on the primary archive while you were away, it's flagged as a conflict instead of being guessed at: you choose whether to keep your offline edit, keep what's on primary, or leave it for later. Once you're done, it offers to point Edit back at the primary folder.

Settings

Five groups:

- **Locations** — the folders the app reads from and writes to: Edit, Ingest, Pending, Rejected, Reviewed, and Released. The first five are moved between automatically by Import/Submit/

Approve/Reject; *Released* has no button of its own anywhere in the app — it's wherever you archive a reviewed record off to by hand once it's actually ready to publish.

- **Application Data** (“Clutter folder”) — where the app keeps its own files (the shared version history behind Audits, and the vocabulary-search cache) separate from the archive itself. Leave blank to use the sensible default shown.
- **Offline Work** — see **Working offline** above.
- **User** — your full name, used to label your own Saves/Submits/ Approvals in Audits.
- **Options** — a handful of less-common preferences, most usefully **media_extensions**: which file extensions count as a record's linked media file for Sync Media and for Submit/Approve/Reject carrying it along. Leave blank for a broad, sensible default (shown as a placeholder in the field itself).

Changes take effect the next time a folder is used — for instance, the next time you click Open.

Tips and troubleshooting

- **“No ‘X’ folder is configured”** — open Settings and set that folder before trying the action again.
- **“Couldn't reach that folder”** — Save/Submit/Approve/Reject couldn't actually write to the configured location (a network share that's gone offline is the usual cause). Nothing is lost — your edits are still in the open record — but that particular save didn't happen. If this is a recurring problem rather than a one-off outage, see **Working offline** above.
- **Submit refuses with a validation error** — the message explains what the schema requires; the detailed technical error is available too if you need it.
- Undo is your safety net for anything done inside the app. It does **not** cover Sync Media's actual file-writing step (it modifies the linked image's metadata directly, outside the XML record) — that's why Sync asks for confirmation before it runs.